



#AI4Elections Hackathon | Artificial Intelligence for Electoral Innovation, Integrity & Inclusion

CONCEPT DOCUMENT

Announcement Date - 1st October 2026

Project Period - October 2026 – February 2027

Format - National, multidisciplinary and nonpartisan

A Project of Rise Networks in collaboration with Technical Partners and Relevant Agencies

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The #AI4Elections Hackathon is a national electoral innovation project conceptualized by Rise Networks to mobilise Nigeria's technology ecosystem, academic institutions, young innovators, researchers, developers and civil society around the responsible application of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies to electoral processes.

As artificial intelligence becomes increasingly influential in information production, digital communications, public administration and civic participation, there's a growing need for practical, evidence-based and responsible tech solutions that can strengthen electoral integrity, improve access to reliable information, support transparency and expand inclusion. Nigeria's electoral environment presents an opportunity to bring together technical talent and electoral expertise to develop solutions that respond to real-world challenges, while protecting fundamental rights, privacy, institutional independence and public trust.

The #AI4Elections Hackathon will provide a structured platform for participants to identify electoral challenges, collaborate across disciplines, build and demonstrate working prototypes, conduct research and develop technology-enabled approaches to electoral innovation.

The Project will be delivered through three connected pillars:

- i. *The #AI4Elections Hackathon* - the national competition and innovation showcase.
- ii. *The #AI4Elections Infrastructure Lab* - a post-hackathon incubation and validation programme.
- iii. *The #AI4Elections Community of Practice* - a sustained non-partisan national network of innovators, developers, researchers, universities, electoral experts, civic organisations and tech partners working on the responsible use of AI and technology for electoral integrity, inclusion and ethical public participation.

Rise Networks is the independent Programme owner. INEC, relevant public institutions, universities, technology companies, civil society organisations and development partners are welcome to participate in appropriate institutional, technical, research, mentorship and sponsorship capacities. The inaugural edition begins on Nigeria's Independence Day, 1st October 2026, culminating in a national hackathon and semi final in Lagos in January 2026 and the grand finale in Abuja in February 2027, followed by a structured incubation and institutional engagement programme. The ultimate objective is to establish a recurring

Nigerian platform for developing responsible electoral technology, strengthening national AI talent and supporting public-interest innovation beyond a single electoral cycle.

2. BACKGROUND AND RATIONALE

Artificial intelligence is transforming the way people access information, communicate, analyse data and interact with public institutions. Its applications offer opportunities for improving public services and civic participation, but also introduce risks relating to synthetic media, misinformation, privacy, cybersecurity, algorithmic bias and the manipulation of information environments. Elections are particularly sensitive to these developments because they depend on public confidence, accurate information, institutional accountability, transparent processes and the ability of citizens to participate freely. Nigeria has a growing ecosystem of technology entrepreneurs, AI researchers, university-based innovators, software developers, data scientists and civic technology organisations but the people developing technology and the people with deep knowledge of electoral processes do not always have structured opportunities to work together. The #AI4Elections Hackathon seeks to bridge this gap as it will connect electoral problem owners and subject-matter experts with technical talent, enabling teams to move from problem identification to research, prototyping, testing and potential implementation.

The Hackathon is not intended to develop partisan campaign technology, influence voter preferences or interfere with electoral administration. It is designed to support nonpartisan, public-interest innovation that respects electoral law, democratic rights and responsible AI principles. By creating a structured pipeline for talent development, prototype evaluation, research and institutional engagement, Rise Networks aims to contribute to a stronger ecosystem for responsible electoral technology in Nigeria.

3. PROJECT GOAL

Goal: To establish a national platform that mobilises Nigerian and Africa-connected talent to develop, test and promote responsible AI and technology solutions for electoral integrity, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation.

4. OBJECTIVES

This Programme seeks to:

1. Identify and support practical AI and technology solutions addressing clearly defined electoral challenges.
2. Mobilise multidisciplinary talent from universities, technology companies, research institutions, startups and civil society.
3. Strengthen technical capacity in AI engineering, data science, cybersecurity, electoral technology, responsible AI and civic innovation.
4. Encourage evidence-based research into the opportunities, risks and governance implications of AI in elections.
5. Facilitate collaboration between innovators and relevant electoral, academic, public-sector and civil society stakeholders.
6. Establish a national database and sustained community of electoral innovators, researchers, developers, mentors and institutional partners.
7. Support promising prototypes through incubation, technical validation, mentorship and potential institutional pilots, subject to relevant approvals.
8. Produce practical research, policy recommendations and an annual electoral innovation report.

5. PROJECT CORE & SUSTAINABILITY STRATEGY

The #AI4Elections Hackathon 2026 - 2027 is conceived not as a standalone competition, but as the foundation of a sustainable, multi-year national platform for responsible artificial intelligence, electoral innovation and democratic participation in Nigeria. Following the conclusion of the inaugural edition, Rise Networks will work with its partners to establish a structured post-

hackathon pathway through which promising solutions will receive continued technical mentorship, product refinement, incubation support, infrastructure access and opportunities for responsible piloting and deployment, subject to appropriate institutional approvals. The initiative will also seek to establish an enduring #AI4Elections community of developers, researchers, university students, civic innovators and technology entrepreneurs, supported by continuous capacity-building programmes, research collaborations, knowledge-sharing activities and partnerships with technology companies, academic institutions, electoral stakeholders and development organisations. Through subsequent annual editions, strategic partner commitments, institutional collaboration, resource mobilisation and the development of an #AI4Elections research and knowledge platform, Rise Networks plans to build a sustainable national ecosystem that continuously develops locally relevant AI solutions, strengthens Nigeria's electoral technology capacity and contributes to more inclusive, transparent, accessible and accountable democratic processes. The long-term ambition is to establish #AI4Elections as a recognised African platform for responsible electoral AI innovation, with the capacity to support research, talent development, technology testing and cross-country knowledge exchange across the continent.

Pillar 1 | #AI4Elections Hackathon

National open call, team formation, bootcamps, innovation challenges, prototype development, judging, awards and grand finale.

Pillar 2 | #AI4Elections Innovation Lab

Post-hackathon incubation, technical testing, safety reviews, mentorship, product refinement, research development and potential institutional pilots.

Pillar 3 | #AI4Elections Community

National registry, university chapters, technical and research sessions, mentorship network, alumni engagement and continuing innovation challenges. These pillars are designed as a connected programme, and the hackathon is expected to identify talent and promising solutions; the Innovation Lab will support selected projects; and the community will sustain participation and collaboration over time.

6. #AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON TRACKS

The inaugural edition will feature five principal challenge areas.

Track 1: AI and Electoral Information Integrity

Solutions for detecting, assessing and responding to AI-generated or manipulated electoral information, synthetic media, impersonation and misleading content. Outputs are expected to include verification tools, provenance systems, multilingual fact-checking assistance and responsible information-analysis systems.

Track 2: Electoral Data Intelligence

Responsible applications of AI for analysing authorised electoral datasets, improving data quality, processing public documents, supporting logistics analysis and identifying data anomalies for human review. Solutions must not independently declare electoral results or substitute algorithmic outputs for legally authorised electoral processes.

Track 3: Inclusive and Multilingual Civic Technology

Accessible voter-information tools, Nigerian-language civic information, assistive interfaces, digital literacy solutions and technology addressing barriers to electoral participation.

Track 4: Electoral Cybersecurity and Resilience

Defensive tools, authorised sandbox simulations, security monitoring concepts, privacy-preserving systems and resilience approaches for electoral technology. No testing of live electoral systems or unauthorised access to institutional infrastructure will be permitted.

Track 5: Election Observation and Citizen Accountability

Tools for structured observation reporting, incident documentation, civic feedback, public information access and transparency, with appropriate safeguards for observers and citizens. Final problem statements will be developed with relevant subject-matter experts and prospective institutional partners. Participation by an institution will not imply endorsement of any solution.

7. PARTICIPANTS AND ELIGIBILITY

The programme will be open to eligible Nigerian and Africa-connected participants, including:

- University students, recent graduates and postgraduate researchers.
- Software developers, AI engineers, data scientists and cybersecurity professionals.
- Academic researchers, lecturers and independent scholars.
- Startups, technology entrepreneurs and civic-tech innovators.
- Electoral experts, election observers and civil society practitioners.
- Product designers, accessibility specialists, linguists and communication researchers.
- Public-policy, governance, legal and data protection professionals.
- Emerging innovators and young people through a supervised youth pathway.
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Applications may be submitted by individuals or existing teams, and individual applicants will have an opportunity to participate in structured team matching. The main competition team size is four to six members, and the hackathon seeks broad participation across Nigeria's six geopolitical zones, with targeted outreach to women, persons with disabilities, underserved communities and institutions outside major technology centres. Secondary school participants will be considered through an age-appropriate, supervised youth category.

8. COMPETITION DELIVERABLES

The principal competition deliverable is a working prototype or technically credible proof of concept addressing a defined electoral problem. Depending on the track, eligible outputs are expected to include:

- AI-enabled applications, tools and dashboards.
- Software prototypes, models and data-analysis pipelines.
- Research papers, policy briefs and technical methodologies.
- Accessible civic technology and multilingual information interfaces.
- Open-source components, technical documentation and evaluation frameworks.

Every competing team is required to demonstrate the problem it is addressing, explain its methodology, present evidence of functionality or technical feasibility, document limitations and outline the safeguards and conditions required for further testing. The programme will distinguish between concepts, prototypes, independently evaluated solutions and institutionally approved deployments. Winning a competition does not constitute approval for operational deployment.

9. IMPLEMENTATION PLAN AND TIMELINE

1st October: Official announcement of the AI for Elections Hackathon and strategic partners;

October: Public launch, partner engagement, participant registration and awareness campaign;

October to November: Community outreach, onboarding, technical orientation and capacity-building sessions;

November to January: Team formation, ideation, mentorship, technical development and prototype testing;

January to February: Solution refinement, judging, demonstrations and selection of finalists;

February: Grand finale, presentation of awards and announcement of winning teams; and

Post-February: Continued public relations, impact reporting, technical mentorship, solution refinement, pilot discussions and potential acceleration support for selected teams.

Institutional partners are identified accurately, and their roles and logos are included only with written permission. Given the scheduled 2027 elections, the programme prioritises research, prototype development and controlled evaluation in the pre-election period. Any operational electoral deployment has to comply with the relevant legal, institutional, technical and security approvals.

10. SEMI FINAL, GRAND FINALE AND NATIONAL SHOWCASE

The inaugural semi finale will take place in Lagos, Nigeria, in January 2027 with the Grand Finale in Abuja in February 2027. Lagos will serve as the national convening location for the hackathon, technical demonstrations, innovation exhibition, final judging, awards and recognition of participants. A separate institutional and policy showcase in Abuja will be organised subsequently to present selected outcomes to relevant electoral institutions, public-sector stakeholders, research organisations and potential implementation partners. The two-city approach is intended to combine a technology-focused national competition with sustained institutional engagement, without duplicating the main hackathon.

11. PRIZES AND AWARDS

The Total cash prize pool is **₦10 million** for the overall winner, alongside awards for runners-up and specialist categories.

Grand Prize - 1st Place - Overall Champion - Best overall AI-for-elections solution - ₦4,000,000

2nd Place - Runner-up - Second-highest overall score - ₦2,500,000

3rd Place - Second Runner-up - Third-highest overall score - ₦1,500,000

SPECIAL INNOVATION AWARDS

- a. Research and Policy Innovation Award** - Best misinformation detection, verification or electoral information solution - **₦500,000**
- b. Electoral and Civic Inclusion Award** - Best solution for accessibility, multilingual participation or underserved voters - **₦500,000**
- c. Responsible AI and Safety Award** - Best data-driven solution for electoral analysis or accountability - **₦500,000**
- d. Cybersecurity and Resilience Award** - Best solution addressing election-related digital security or system resilience - **₦500,000**

The four special awards are open to teams across all challenge tracks. A team that wins an overall prize could also win a special award, provided it meets the criteria as that allows exceptional teams to receive more than one award while maintaining a transparent judging framework.

Important Details

- Prize money will be awarded to winning teams, not individual members. Each team is expected to identify a designated recipient and agree on how the funds will be distributed.
- The judging rubric will include technical quality, electoral relevance, innovation, feasibility, inclusion, privacy and responsible AI.
- The ₦10 million is the prize pool only. Mentorship, cloud credits, incubation and technical resources from partners are listed separately as confirmed commitments.

In addition to cash prizes, the Hackathon may be able to provide access to:

- Laptops and development equipment.
- Cloud and AI compute credits.
- Software, API and developer-tool access.
- Technical mentorship and incubation.
- Research and product-development support.
- Opportunities for professional exposure and institutional engagement.

All prizes and in-kind benefits will be disclosed transparently, with final award values and conditions published before the competition.

12. JUDGING AND EVALUATION FRAMEWORK

Projects will be evaluated using published criteria:

Criterion	Weight
Technical functionality and innovation	25%
Electoral relevance and practical usefulness	20%
Cybersecurity, privacy and responsible AI	20%
Inclusion, accessibility and multilingual capability	15%
Scalability, sustainability and feasibility	15%
Demonstration and documentation	5%
Total	100%

Research and youth categories may use adapted criteria appropriate to their deliverables and Judges will be selected for technical, electoral, academic, governance and civic expertise. Conflicts of interest must be disclosed, and judges will not score teams from which they stand to benefit or which they have materially mentored. Projects presenting critical security, privacy, safety or legal concerns may be excluded from awards or further testing, regardless of their technical score.

13. POST-HACKATHON INNOVATION LAB

The #AI4Elections Infrastructure Lab will support a selected cohort of approximately five to eight promising teams, subject to funding and mentor capacity. The incubation period is eight to twelve weeks. Support may include technical mentorship, code review, product development, access to compute resources, research collaboration, responsible-AI assessments, user research and potential introductions to institutions and funders. The Lab will not guarantee funding, procurement, institutional adoption or operational deployment. Any institutional pilot will require a written agreement, defined scope, relevant approvals and appropriate safeguards. The Lab will encourage a range of sustainable pathways, including independent startups, research collaborations, open-source projects, nonprofit initiatives and institutionally supported solutions.

14. AI4ELECTIONS COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE AND NATIONAL REGISTRY

As the Hackathon reaches a close, Rise Networks will set up the #AI4Elections community of practice as a permanent national network for electoral technology and responsible AI. The community of practice will maintain a consent-based registry of participants, researchers, developers, mentors, institutions and alumni and its activities will include monthly technical and research sessions, quarterly project clinics, university chapters, mentorship, newsletters, research collaborations and annual innovation challenges. The registry will capture professional interests, skills, affiliations and preferred opportunities, with clear privacy notices, appropriate access controls and mechanisms for members to update or withdraw their information. The community of practice will support sustained collaboration and provide a talent and research pipeline for future public-interest technology initiatives.

15. GOVERNANCE AND PARTNERSHIP FRAMEWORK

Rise Networks is the Principal Project owner, independent organiser and secretariat. Its responsibilities are programme design, fundraising, partner coordination, application management, competition administration, community development, reporting and post-hackathon support. The Hackathon seeks partnerships in the following areas:

Partner Category	Contribution
Electoral institutions	Subject-matter expertise, approved challenge inputs and technical engagement.
AI Experts and Firms	AI expertise, compute access, training, mentorship and technical resources.
Universities and research centres	Talent mobilisation, research, technical mentoring and evaluation.
Civil society and electoral research organisations	Electoral problem validation, civic expertise, inclusion and accountability.
Technology companies	Sponsorship, cloud credits, equipment, software, API access and technical support.
Development partners and foundations	Programme funding, inclusion, research, incubation and capacity development.

All institutional participation will be subject to appropriate approvals. Rise Networks will retain responsibility for programme governance, while each partner will retain control of its own systems, data, policies and deployment decisions.

16. SAFEGUARDING, ETHICS AND RESPONSIBLE AI GUIDELINES

The Hackathon will operate under the following principles:

- Non - Partisanship and equal treatment of participants.
- Respect for electoral law, fundamental rights and freedom of expression.
- No partisan voter persuasion, political microtargeting or manipulation of electoral participation.
- No unauthorised access to or testing of live electoral systems.
- Use of synthetic, public or explicitly authorised datasets.
- Protection of personal information and confidential institutional data.
- Human oversight of consequential decisions and clear documentation of model limitations.
- Accessibility and inclusion in programme design and technology development.
- Transparent prize rules, intellectual property terms and conflict-of-interest management.

All teams will be required to sign a participant code of conduct and comply with the published technical and data-use rules.

17. MONITORING, EVALUATION AND LEARNING

The Hackathon will measure performance across participation, innovation, capacity development, community growth and post-event outcomes. The First-edition planning targets include:

Indicator	Target
Applications	300 to 500 individuals
Universities represented	Minimum of 15
Teams selected for the programme	25 - 40
Finalist projects	8 - 12
Incubation cohort	5 - 8 teams
Opted-in community members	300+

Additional indicators include diversity of participation, prototype functionality, completion of technical reviews, post-event team retention, mentorship engagement, research outputs and potential institutional pilots. Rise Networks will produce an inaugural outcome report documenting participation, projects, awards, lessons learned, responsible-AI assessments and recommendations for future editions. In-kind contributions such as cloud credits, laptops, equipment, venue support and professional services will be separately documented and will not be represented as cash funding.

19. SPONSORSHIP AND PARTNERSHIP OPPORTUNITIES

Rise Networks invites technology companies, financial institutions, telecommunications providers, development partners, foundations, universities and research institutions to support the inaugural edition.

Partnership opportunities include:

- Title and principal sponsorship.
- Prize pool sponsorship.
- Cloud, AI and developer infrastructure sponsorship.
- Laptops and equipment sponsorship.
- University and youth participation sponsorship.
- Research and innovation incubation sponsorship.
- Travel, accommodation and national outreach sponsorship.
- Technical mentorship, judging and institutional engagement.

Sponsors may support the programme through financial contributions or clearly defined in-kind support, subject to Rise Networks' sponsorship policies, non- partisanship principles and conflict-of-interest safeguards.

20. CONCLUSION

The #AI4Elections Hackathon represents an opportunity to connect Nigeria's technology talent with the needs of electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation. Through the combined strengths of competition, incubation and community-building, Rise Networks intends to create a platform where technical talent and electoral expertise can collaborate to develop practical, responsible and evidence-based solutions. The inaugural edition will serve as the foundation for a recurring national initiative that supports AI talent development, public-interest innovation, independent research and constructive engagement with electoral stakeholders. Rise Networks welcomes partnerships with institutions and individuals committed to responsible technology, electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation.